



The Words Before the Story

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

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About This Book

This booklet is the six live sittings called *Citizens — Constitution & Declaration*. Those sittings are already on the academy for young, emerging, and adult. There is no little sitting. This elementary booklet is aged from the young sittings so a grown-up can hold the same spine with a 5–10-year-old. It is not the Hour book *History for Homeschooling*. It is not the civic *figure* packs (Federalist, Magna Carta, Constitution, Declaration, Fourteenth). Those are different products. This spine is six practices: read the words first, hear the Declaration as a speech, see the Constitution as a design, name who was not in the room, see that the republic can change, and practice being a citizen at the table.

A grown-up is in the room. Synthetic names only. No real child data. We read real words from the founding documents. We do not skip the ugly parts. We do not preach. We read.

The six sittings already live (young+): `words-before-story`, `declaration-rhetoric`, `constitution-design`, `missing-voices-founding`, `amendment-process`, `citizens-capstone`. Sitting 1 is `/learn/young/history/words-before-story`. This booklet does not replace them. It lets you run the same law with smaller hands.

Hard rule for this band: the object is the page. Recaps, videos, and model summaries come second. If the page was not opened, the sitting did not happen. If the ugly clause was skipped while the pretty sentence was framed on the wall, the sitting did not happen either. Look first. The document is the source.

Chapter 1: The Words Before the Story



Illustration for Chapter 1

Before anyone tells you what the Founders meant, read what they wrote.

A grown-up opens a paper. Not a video about the paper. Not a model's recap of the paper. The paper. The first sentence of the Declaration of Independence is long. It is also short

enough to say out loud. You listen. Then you write what it says — not what you think it means. Meaning comes second. Words come first.

A talking tool can summarize that sentence in one breath. The summary will sound smooth. Smooth is not the same as complete. The summary will add a little and drop a little. Your job is to catch the drop. If the tool drops “all men,” that is the lesson. If it keeps “all men” and never says the words did not mean all people, that is also the lesson. You name the gap. Naming is not being rude. Naming is reading.

This sitting is not about agreeing with 1776. It is about not letting a recap stand in for a document. A citizen reads the source. A fan reads the story. We are practicing citizens.

The young sitting, same law: before a textbook tells you what the Founders meant, read what they wrote. Write what the sentence says. Then read a summary. What did it add? What did it drop? “All men” did not mean all people. Write that. The gap is the lesson. Do not cite a model summary as the source. The words are the source.

If they say “I know what the Declaration says.”: You might know a recap. Read the actual words. The recap and the words are not the same.

If they say “The Founders were hypocrites.”: Some were. Read the words and name the gap. “Hypocrites” without the words is a slogan. The words plus the gap is the reading.

Objective. The child, with a grown-up, can hear one sentence from the Declaration, say what the words say, and notice one thing a summary added or dropped.

For the grown-up in the room. Stay. Do not sermonize the Founders. Read the words, including the ones that sit badly now. “All men” did not mean all people. Say that. Do not erase it. Do not outsource the reading to a model. The model is a summary machine. The reading is yours.

Words to Remember

“We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.” — Declaration of Independence (1776)

What it says: they claimed equality and three rights. What it did not say: women, enslaved people, Indigenous people. Both facts are the reading.

Big Idea

Read the words before the story. The summary adds and drops. The gap is the lesson. Name the ugly gaps too.

Try This

1. Grown-up reads the sentence above slowly. Child writes or says what it says. 2. Ask a model to summarize the same sentence. Save the summary. 3. Circle one add and one drop. Write: “all men did not mean all people.” 4. **Integrity.** We do not cite a model summary as the Declaration. The words are the source. The summary is compression. Label both. We do not hide that we used a tool.

Hard edges, same as the sitting: do not sermonize the Founders. Read the words, including the ones that are ugly by today’s standards. The Declaration says “all men.” It did not mean all people. That gap is real. Name it. Do not erase it.

Materials: a printed or screen copy of the Declaration’s first page, a pencil, a grown-up. Optional: one model query *after* the writing. No child name in the query. The query is the sentence, not the child’s life.

Dinner question from the sitting: What words did we read today from the founding, and what did the summary miss?

Ask a Grown-Up

If a recap is easier, why do we still read the hard page first?

Chapter 2: A Speech, Not a Spell



Illustration for Chapter 2

The Declaration is not a magic paper. It is a speech. People meant it to be heard.

A speech tries three jobs. It says *who may speak* (ethos). It gives *reasons and a list* (logos). It tugs a *shared feeling or moral sense* (pathos). Aristotle named those jobs long before 1776.

The Declaration uses all three. You do not need the Greek words to hear them. You need ears.

Listen for the opening: “When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary...” That line claims the right to speak. Listen for the list: “He has refused... He has forbidden... He has obstructed...” That is evidence, some sharp, some foggy. Listen for the appeal to a judge of the world. That is feeling joined to a claim.

A model can find the three labels if you ask. You find them first. Then you check. If you only take the model’s labels, you did not read a speech. You rented a worksheet.

Do not shrink the Declaration into a rhetoric game and forget it is also history. The lens is one lens. The document is still a document.

The young sitting asks for one example of each appeal and a reason. Emerging audits claim / evidence / conclusion and names a weakness. Adult reads the whole Declaration aloud (~1,300 words, about ten minutes) and names one appeal and one weakness in the same sitting. You are not doing the emerging audit at this band. You are training the ear so that later audit has something to audit.

If they say “It’s just an old document.”: It is a speech that uses the same jobs every speech uses. Hearing the jobs is how you see how it works, not only what it claims.

If they say “It’s too long to read aloud.”: The whole Declaration is shorter than many bedtime stories. Two paragraphs is enough tonight. The whole speech can wait for a Saturday.

Objective. The child can point to one place that claims a right to speak, one place that lists reasons, and one place that tugs feeling — with a grown-up’s help.

For the grown-up in the room. Ten minutes aloud is enough. Name one appeal and one weakness. Stop. If they ask about “all men,” answer. Do not dodge.

Words to Remember

“When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another...” — Declaration of Independence, opening

That sentence is ethos: we claim the standing to act.

Big Idea

The Declaration is a speech. Hear it. Name one craft move and one weak spot. Scripture without audit is faith. Audit without hearing is cynicism. Both together is the sitting.

Try This

1. Grown-up reads the first two paragraphs aloud. 2. Child points: “This part asks us to feel.” “This part lists.” “This part says we may speak.” 3. Name one weakness: a vague grievance, or “all men” not meaning all people. 4. Ask the model to find ethos, pathos, logos *after* you have pointed. Compare. Cite the model if you used it.

Ask a Grown-Up

What did hearing it aloud do that a silent recap did not?

Chapter 3: A Design, Not a List



Illustration for Chapter 3

The Constitution is not a poster of three words. It is a design for a government.

Someone writes laws. Someone carries them out. Someone judges them. That is legislative, executive, judicial — Article I, Article II, Article III. Each can stop the others. A veto. An

override. A court. Advice and consent. The people who wrote it had seen a king with too many hands on the wheel. They did not trust one pile of power. The design is the distrust made into a machine.

A list of branch names is memorization. A child who can say *why three* has begun to see the design. A talking tool will happily list the branches. Ask it to explain the design, not the list. If it only lists, that is the lesson.

The design includes an ugly bargain. Enslaved people were counted as three-fifths of a person for representation and could not vote. That is in the document. It was a compromise so states would sign. Brilliant design. Ugly price. Both are the Constitution. Skipping the bargain is a cleaned-up story. We do not clean it up.

Article V is also design: the paper can change without a war of succession. You will meet that in chapter 5. Tonight, stay with the three jobs and one check. If they already “know the three branches,” ask *why three*. The list is school. The why is the sitting.

If they say “I know the three branches.”: You know the list. Do you know the design? Why checks? Why not one branch with all the power?

If they say “The Constitution is outdated.”: Parts of it were changed on purpose. That is chapter 5. First see the machine. Then talk about changing a gear.

Objective. The child can name three jobs in the design (write / carry out / judge) and one way one job can stop another — and hear that an ugly compromise is in the same paper.

For the grown-up in the room. One article is enough. Name one feature and one tension. Do not sermonize. Do not skip three-fifths when you reach it.

Words to Remember

*“We the People of the United States, in Order to form a more perfect Union, establish Justice, insure domestic Tranquility, provide for the common defence, promote the general Welfare, and secure the Blessings of Liberty to ourselves and our Posterity, do ordain and establish this Constitution for the United States of America.” —
Constitution of the United States, Preamble*

“More perfect” is a design phrase. It admits the union is not finished.

“...three fifths of all other Persons.” — Constitution of the United States, Article I, Section 2

That is the three-fifths clause. Enslaved people were counted as three-fifths of a person for representation and could not vote. It is in the design. It is ugly. Read it when you reach it. Do not skip it to keep the Preamble pretty.

Big Idea

The Constitution is a design: who has power, who checks it, who can change it. The design is clever. The bargains can be ugly. Read both.

Try This

1. Three cards: WRITE LAWS, CARRY OUT, JUDGE. Child sorts them. 2. Act one check: “I veto.” “We override.” Freeze. Name the check. 3. Grown-up says, plainly: enslaved people were counted as three-fifths and could not vote. That is in the design. It is ugly. It is ours to name. 4. Dinner: What part of the design did we see, and what bargain did we name?

Ask a Grown-Up

Why not give one person every job?

Chapter 4: Who Was Not in the Room?



Illustration for Chapter 4

The Declaration said “all men.” The room did not hold all people.

Who wrote? Men, most with property, some who enslaved other people. Who was not there? Women. Enslaved people. Indigenous nations. People without property. The paper

came from that room. The gap between the words and the room is not a footnote. It is the history.

This sitting is not a takedown. It is not a pep rally. It is a seating chart. If the missing people had been in the room, would the sentence have been the same? You do not need a perfect counterfactual. You need one named group and one honest “it would have been different.”

A model summary often skips the empty chairs. If it recites equality and never names the room, that is the drop. You name the chairs. The model is a compression. Compression is not neutral.

Keep it concrete. One group. One difference. Do not drown a 7-year-old in every crime of the eighteenth century. Do not pretend the room was full.

The young sitting asks: if enslaved people had been in the room, would the document have said “all men”? You may not get a clever essay. You should get an honest pause. Emerging will connect this to the thinking unit on missing voices. Adult will read an ugly clause at the table without flinching. Tonight is the seating chart only.

If they say “That was a long time ago.”: It is in the paper we still use. Old is not the same as gone.

If they say “Then the paper is bad.”: The paper claimed a promise and broke it in the same room. Citizens keep the promise and name the break. Throwing the paper away without reading it is another skip.

Objective. The child can name one group who was not in the room and say, with a grown-up, that the paper would have been different if they had been.

For the grown-up in the room. Honest, not theatrical. Do not dismiss the founding. Do not baptize it. Name one missing voice. Stop.

Words to Remember

“all men are created equal” — Declaration of Independence (1776)

Say it. Then say who was not counted in the room that wrote it. Both sentences are required.

“What, to the American slave, is your 4th of July? I answer; a day that reveals to him, more than all other days in the year, the gross injustice and cruelty to which he is the constant victim.” — Frederick Douglass, “What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?” (Rochester, 5 July 1852)

You do not read the whole speech at this age. You hear that a missing voice spoke back, in public, with a date. The grown-up can keep the rest for later.

Big Idea

The founding was written by a room that did not include everyone. The gap between the words and the room is the history. Naming it is literacy, not guilt theater.

Try This

1. Draw a table. Put “in the room” on one side, “not in the room” on the other. Fill with the grown-up. 2. Read “all men are created equal.” Point to the empty chairs. 3. Ask: if the empty chairs had spoken, would that sentence stay the same? Write one sentence of answer. 4. Ask the model to summarize the Declaration in one paragraph. Did it name the empty chairs? If not, that is the lesson.

Ask a Grown-Up

Who is missing from a room we sit in now, and do we notice?

Chapter 5: The Republic Can Change



Illustration for Chapter 5

A design that cannot change is a trap. The Constitution can change. That is Article V.

People argue. They vote in states. They amend. The Bill of Rights came soon after, because people who had lost a fight still got amendments. Later amendments ended slavery as a

constitutional fact, counted people as whole persons for representation, and widened who may vote. The document you inherit is not only 1787. It is 1787 plus the changes citizens forced.

A child does not need the full amendment map. They need one picture: the paper is not a stone tablet. Citizens can still write on it, slowly, with many hands. That is harder than a king's pen. That is the point.

If someone says "it's outdated" and walks away, that is a complaint. If someone learns how it changes and uses that path, that is a citizen. Both feelings are allowed. Only one is the practice.

A model will list amendments. You name one change and what it fixed or failed to fix. Lists without a named change are trivia.

The Thirteenth Amendment ended slavery as a constitutional fact. The Fourteenth is its own figure booklet on this academy — do not steal that pack tonight. If you need a voting story, a grown-up may choose the Nineteenth (women) or the Twenty-sixth (eighteen-year-olds) in five true sentences. One story. Not a timeline poster.

If they say "Changing it is too hard.": Hard is the design. A king's pen is easy. Easy is how you get a new king.

If they say "We should just write a new one.": Then you still have to agree. Article V is one path for agreeing. Walking away from every path is not a new constitution. It is leaving the table.

Objective. The child can say the Constitution can be changed, name one change a grown-up chooses (Bill of Rights, or ending slavery in the Constitution, or a voting amendment), and hear that change is slow on purpose.

For the grown-up in the room. Pick one amendment you can tell truly in five sentences. Do not survey all twenty-seven. Do not pretend amendment is easy.

Words to Remember

"The Congress, whenever two thirds of both Houses shall deem it necessary, shall propose Amendments to this Constitution, or, on the Application of the Legislatures of two thirds of the several States, shall call a Convention for proposing Amendments..."
— Constitution of the United States, Article V

Hard on purpose. Many hands. Not one king.

Big Idea

The republic is a practice. The paper can change. Change is slow and shared. That is a feature of the design, not a glitch.

Try This

1. Two papers: “1787” and “later.” Grown-up puts one amendment on “later” and says what it did in one sentence. 2. Child repeats: “The paper can change. It takes many people.” 3. If they say it is too old to bother with: “Then we use the change path, or we are only complaining.” 4. Dinner: What change did we name, and who had to agree?

Ask a Grown-Up

What is one rule in our house that we changed, and who had to agree?

Chapter 6: You Practice Being a Citizen



Illustration for Chapter 6

A citizen is not a mascot. A citizen reads, names gaps, sees the design, and does not outsource the reading.

This last sitting is the week in one shape. You have: words before story; a speech heard aloud; a design with checks; empty chairs named; a paper that can change. Capstone is not a quiz. Capstone is doing one small civic act with a grown-up: read a page, write what it says, name one drop in a summary, name one missing voice, and stop.

Do not let a model write the paragraph. If the model writes it, the name on the page is a lie. Integrity here is the same as every WisdomForge sitting: the try is yours. The tool is second. A grown-up is nearby.

You are not asked to love 1776. You are asked not to fake having read it. You are not asked to hate 1787. You are asked to see the machine, including the ugly gears. That is enough for this band.

Capstone integrity is the same as *Source Before Summary* and *Education in the Age of AI*: the try is first. If MINE is empty — no sentence in their hand — redo or disclose. Do not turn in a model paragraph with their name on it.

The young capstone is “You Are a Citizen.” Emerging is the full practice. Adult is the citizen at the table. You are building the habit that those later sittings assume: a page, a gap, a named chair, a grown-up nearby.

If they say “We’ll figure it out as we go.”: That is how you get a leak. Spec first — here, the spec is the page.

If they say “The child doesn’t need this yet.”: If they live in the republic, they can start with one sentence. Understanding grows. The start is the reading.

Objective. The child and grown-up complete one full pass: read words, catch a summary drop, name one empty chair, and say the paper can change.

For the grown-up in the room. Mark done only if the child (or you, with them) read actual words first. A video recap is not the sitting. A model dump is not the sitting.

Words to Remember

“We the People...” — Constitution, Preamble

People. Not a tool. Not a recap. People who read.

Big Idea

Citizenship at this age is a practice: words first, speech heard, design seen, missing voices named, change possible. The guide is optional. The parent is the teacher. The booklet is the text.

Try This

1. One page: Declaration first paragraph *or* Constitution preamble. Read aloud. 2. Write what it says. No extra meaning. 3. Model summary. Circle one drop. 4. Name one empty chair. Name one way the paper can change. 5. Dinner: What did we actually read this week, and what did we refuse to skip?

Ask a Grown-Up

When did you last read a real civic page, not a recap?

Six labs, one week (optional map)

Use this only if the chapters already ran. It is not six extra sittings.

Lab 1 — Words. One Declaration sentence. Write what it says. Summary second.

Lab 2 — Speech. Read aloud. Point to speak / list / feel.

Lab 3 — Design. Three cards. One check. Name three-fifths without a speech.

Lab 4 — Room. Table of in / not in. One missing group.

Lab 5 — Change. One amendment, five sentences.

Lab 6 — Whole sitting. One page, one drop, one empty chair, stop.

If you skip a day, do not stack two labs to “catch up.” One first hand is the week.

| Practice | First hand | Tool, if any | |---|---|---| | Words | Read the sentence | Summary as a catch, not the source | | Speech | Hear it | Labels after you point | | Design | Sort the jobs | Explain-the-design, not a list | | Room | Name empty chairs | Recap often skips them — that is data | | Change | One amendment story | List of 27 is trivia | | Capstone | One page together | Model does not write the paragraph |

Eleven-to-fourteen will meet founding recaps in search whether you install Hermes or not. This booklet does not make that safe. It makes a check you can run. Safety theater is not the sitting. The sitting is the page and the gap.

If they hide a tool, that is the miss even when the recap is “right.” If they refuse the tool for a week and still read the page, that week is complete. If they refuse the page, that week is not.

You are not asked to become a constitutional lawyer tonight. You are asked to hear a recap as a recap.

Integrity for the week: if a tool was used, say so. If the page was skipped, do not mark the sitting complete. If the child is tired, stop. A half page read honestly beats a full recap performed.

For the Grown-Up Reader

Six live academy sittings (`words-before-story` through `citizens-capstone`), young / emerging / adult. Little sitting **404** by design. This elementary band is aged from the young variants in `history-civics.ts`. Primary text: Declaration of Independence (1776) and Constitution of the United States (1787), including Article I's three-fifths clause and Article V. Rhetoric lens uses Aristotle's three appeals as named in the sitting, not as a full *Rhetoric* course.

This is not the Hour book. It is not Federalist / Magna Carta / Constitution / Declaration / Fourteenth *figure* booklets. Those remain their own packs. No real family data. Do not clone an adult profile into a child's. Nearby means you can hear the lid. It does not mean you write their sentence.

If you only run one lab this week, run chapter 1's sentence. Keep the gap. That gap is worth more than a speech about 1787.

Do not grade their soul. Do not make the model the first read of a live assignment. Do not skip the ugly clauses "until they are older" if you are already reading the pretty ones. The skip teaches that citizenship is only the parts that feel good.

Sources for this band are short on purpose: the Declaration's open and the self-evident sentence; the Constitution's Preamble and the idea of Article V; the fact of the three-fifths clause without turning this booklet into the Fourteenth pack. Aristotle's three appeals appear only as ear-training, the way the young sitting names them. Weizenbaum does not belong here. This is civic text, not ELIZA.

Transfer: Thinking (source before summary), English (the Declaration as speech), CS (the Constitution as a spec with a refuse-list). Keep those as dinner pointers, not extra chapters.

National Archives texts of the Declaration and Constitution are public domain. Read from those, not from a chatbot's memory of them. If your printout and the model disagree, the printout wins. Cite the document. Always the document, never the recap as the source.

About WisdomForge

This is the elementary band of *Citizens — Constitution & Declaration*. Payment pulled. No purchase CTA. The booklet is the text. The parent is the teacher. The guide is optional. Not a hosted kids chatbot. Does not make AI safe.

Four ages, one spine. Middle, high, and adult bands of this pack are separate files. Little academy sittings stay 404 on purpose. Pair from ``/learn/young/history/words-before-story`` when you want the live sitting beside this text. Print the page. Pencil first. Tool second.